

txt2latex(1)

User Commands

09 June 2026

NAME

txt2latex - convert flat ASCII text to $\LaTeX$.

SYNOPSIS

txt2latex [OPTION...] *FILE*

DESCRIPTION

txt2latex converts the input text into $\LaTeX$.

If the input file *FILE* is omitted, standard input is used. The result is displayed on standard output.

txt2latex is also able to recognize sections, paragraphs, lists (itemize, enumerate, description), verbatim blocks, as well as inline math and equations.

The formatting rules are heavily inspired by **txt2man(1)** to maximize compatibility with plain text written as man pages. The same source text can be directly converted to $\LaTeX$ without relying on intermediary conversion steps. Nonetheless, the main objective of **txt2latex** is not to parse man-formatted plain text but to convert any plain text to $\LaTeX$.

The rules for processing the text patterns are defined as following:

Sections They are defined by a line in upper case starting at column 1. Preceding blank lines are allowed for better visualization.

Paragraphs They must be left aligned and preceded by a blank line. Blank spaces at the beginning of the paragraphs are allowed and there is no restriction on line alignment in a paragraph. Nonetheless, identical alignment provides a better visualization of the plain ASCII text.

Description list Labels of the items are separated from the definitions by at least 2 blank spaces, even before a new line, if definition is too long.

Itemize (bullet) list Bullet list items are defined by the first character being "-", "*" or "o" followed by a space.

Enumerated list Enumerated lists are defined by the first character being a number followed by a dot or a rounded bracket.

Nested lists Nested and mixed lists are allowed.

Verbatim block Verbatim block is used to display unmodified text such as quotes of source code. They must be separated by a blank line and be indented with respect to the previous line. It will be printed using the verbatim environment.

Mathematics Inline mathematics must be enclosed with a simple \$ sign and equations must be enclosed with double \$ signs. For example, $E = mc^2$ is rendered as an inline math whereas

$$E = mc^2$$

is rendered in a simple equation environment.

Tables There is no support for tables. The workaround is put them in a verbatim block.

Special characters #, \$, %, &, _, {, }, ^ \ are protected i.e. escaped.

Symbols such as <, >, <=, >= are converted to inline math.

URLs such as www.github.com/MilanSkocic/txt2latex are converted to hyper-references. The URLs must start with http(s)://.

Special words such as $\LaTeX$ and $\TeX$ are turned into their equivalent commands in latex.

OPTIONS

-d date Set date. Defaults to current date.

-t mytitle Set the title. If the title is set, txt2latex will automatically add all the markups necessary to create a standalone latex document that can be compiled with pdflatex. Xelatex and lualatex are not supported.

-a author Set the author.

-s shift Shift heading level by 0 (section), 1 (subsection), or 2 (subsection). Defaults to 0.

-m, -man Apply some special formatting for man pages. See NOTES.

-I txt Italicize txt in output. Can be specified more than once.

-B txt Emphasize (bold) txt in output. Can be specified more than once.

-M txt Monospace txt in output. Can be specified more than once.

-P package Add packages or $\LaTeX$ or $\TeX$ commands in the preamble.

-u, -usage Display synopsis.

-v, -version Display version.

-h, -help Display help.

NOTES

The option -m is an alpha feature and not fully implemented. The formatting is done by applying the adequate preamble in a standalone document for matching the rendering of man -Tpdf. For now:

- SYNOPSIS section is formatted as monospaced text.
- Set font to times.
- Set correct paragraph indentation.

EXAMPLES

Simple conversion

```
$ txt2latex FILE > FILE.tex
```

Conversion with document title

```
$ txt2latex -t "title" -a "author" -I "word" FILE > FILE.tex
```

Conversion with custom packages and direct rendering with pdflatex

```
$ txt2latex -t "title" -a "author" -I "word" -P "\\usepackage{ccfonts}" | pdflatex -jobna
```

Try this command to format this text itself and to produce a pdf:

```
$ txt2latex -h 2>&1 | txt2latex -t "txt2latex(1)" -a "User commands" --man | pdflatex -jo
```

Compare it to the man page generated by txt2man(1):

```
$ txt2latex -h 2>&1 | txt2man -s 1 -t txt2latex -v "User commands" -r 0.5.0 | man -l -Tpd
```

SEE ALSO

txt2man(1)